BANNED: THE DEFINITIVE GUIDE

INTRODUCTION

This document is a personal style guide—a catalog of words, phrases, constructions, and patterns that I don't want to see in my own writing. It exists because I got tired of catching the same problems in revision, and because working with AI tools requires explicit boundaries to prevent regression to generic, statistically-average prose.

I'm a content maximalist and a militant anti-tropist. My tolerance for cliché is low. My list of banned elements is long. Some of what's cataloged here represents genuinely weak writing—vague placeholders, dead metaphors, mechanical rhythms that substitute form for content. But some of it is simply personal preference: common literary constructs that work fine for other writers but that I find grating, overused, or tonally wrong for my projects.

This is not a universal prescription. It's not "if you use these, you're a bad writer." It's "if *I* use these, I've gotten lazy, and I need to fix it."

The document is organized into four parts:

- **Part 1: Constructions** — Syntactic and structural patterns to avoid
- **Part 2: Words and Phrases** — Specific vocabulary and phrase-level bans
- **Part 3: Guidelines** — Principles, protocols, and revision checklists
- **Part 4: Erotica-Specific** — Additional rules governing explicit content

Use what applies. Ignore what doesn't. Adapt freely. The goal isn't compliance with my preferences—it's clarity about your own. If nothing else, this document might help you identify patterns you've never noticed, so you can decide for yourself whether they serve your work or undermine it.

Chew the meat. Spit out the bones.

PART 1: CONSTRUCTIONS

Purpose

This section catalogs **syntactic and structural patterns** that weaken prose through mechanical repetition, false rhythm, or decorative vagueness. These are not word-level problems—they're architectural habits that simulate depth, tension, or emotion without creating it.

Core Principle: Every construction listed here substitutes form for content. The fix is always the same: name what's actually happening, show consequence, or cut.

1.1 SEQUENTIAL ACTION PAIRS

Pattern: "X, then Y"

What It Looks Like:

- "He stands, then sits."
- "She speaks, then falls silent."
- "He reaches out, then pulls back."

Why It Fails:

- Creates robotic pacing—every action reads identically
- Removes emotional transition between gestures
- Reads as stage direction rather than lived movement

Flagging Trigger: If you write ", then" between two actions, pause. Ask: Does this sequence reveal psychology, or am I just choreographing motion?

1.2 VAGUE INTERIORITY PLACEHOLDER

Pattern: "Something [verbs] in/behind [body part]"

What It Looks Like:

- "Something shifts behind his eyes."
- "Something tightens in her chest."
- "Something flickers in his expression."
- "Something hardens in her voice."

Why It Fails:

- "Something" signals the writer knows an effect occurred but can't specify what
- Treats emotion as mysterious rather than observable

- Creates false interiority—tells reader change happened without showing how

Flagging Trigger: If you write "something," stop. Ask: What exactly is happening? What would an observer see or the character feel?

1.3 ANTHROPOMORPHIZED SILENCE

Pattern: "The silence [verbs]"

What It Looks Like:

- "The silence stretches between them."
- "The silence sits heavy in the room."
- "The silence grows uncomfortable."
- "The silence hangs, thick and suffocating."

Why It Fails:

- Turns silence into an actor rather than showing its effect
- Empty beat that simulates tension without creating it
- Stops momentum by naming atmosphere instead of dramatizing consequence

Flagging Trigger: If silence "does" something (stretches, sits, presses, hangs), rewrite to show who breaks it, who endures it, what it costs.

1.4 NEGATION FORMULA

Pattern: "Not X, but Y"

What It Looks Like:

- "Not angry, but resigned."
- "Not a question, but a statement."
- "Not love, but something close."
- "Not fear, but caution."

Why It Fails:

- Hedges instead of commits
- Signals authorial indecision
- Becomes rhythmic tic—every nuanced feeling gets the same syntactic treatment

Flagging Trigger: If you write "not [X], but [Y]," ask: What is this actually? Can I name it directly?

1.5 TRIPLE-BEAT LISTS

Pattern: Three-part noun/fragment sequences for emphasis

What It Looks Like:

- "The exhaustion. The loneliness. The endurance."
- "The wine. The laughter. The silence."
- "The blood. The breath. The waiting."

Why It Fails:

- Mimics poetic seriousness through structure, not content
- Halts narrative flow for rhetorical effect
- Once overused, becomes self-parody

Flagging Trigger: If you write three nouns/fragments in sequence for effect, ask: Am I building tension, or performing it?

1.6 STACCATO VERB FRAGMENTS

Pattern: "[Verb]. [Verb]. [Verb]."

What It Looks Like:

- "Stops. Reaches. Retreats."
- "Looks. Waits. Breathes."
- "Turns. Pauses. Leaves."

Why It Fails:

- Overused in high-emotion beats until robotic
- Creates artificial pacing, erasing natural movement
- Pattern recognition kills power

Flagging Trigger: If you write three single-word verb sentences in a row, ask: Am I building tension, or mimicking it?

1.7 CONJUNCTION STARTS (OVERUSE)

Pattern: Starting sentences with "And" or "But" for performative rhythm

What It Looks Like:

- "And she knows he's lying."
- "But she can't walk away."
- "And still, he waits."

Why It Fails:

- Over-reliance flattens voice
- Creates false intimacy through affected cadence
- Loses impact through repetition

Flagging Trigger: If you start with "And" or "But," ask: Does this sentence need dramatic separation, or am I forcing rhythm?

1.8 STANDALONE "BECAUSE" FRAGMENTS

Pattern: "Because [explanation]." as its own sentence

What It Looks Like:

- "Because she can't bear to look."
- "Because it's easier than lying."
- "Because he's already gone."

Why It Fails:

- Imitates intimacy but signals shorthand thinking
- Backfill explanation instead of lived cause
- Tacks meaning onto flat line

Flagging Trigger: If you write "Because [X]" as a fragment, ask: Can I show this reason through action instead?

1.9 HEDGED REACTIONS

Pattern: "A [reaction] that isn't quite [itself]"

What It Looks Like:

- "A laugh that isn't quite a laugh."
- "A smile that isn't quite a smile."
- "A sigh that isn't quite a sigh."
- "A nod that isn't really agreement."

Why It Fails:

- Creates emotional static—reader can't visualize or feel the gesture
- Substitutes contradiction for depth
- Becomes nervous tic once pattern is recognized

Flagging Trigger: If you write "isn't quite [X]," stop. Ask: What is this gesture actually doing? What does it look like?

1.10 ECHO-LINE POETICS

Pattern: Consecutive sentences with parallel structure for false depth

What It Looks Like:

- "He wanted to be touched. He wanted to be seen."
- "She wasn't angry. She wasn't anything."
- "It wasn't the silence. It was the waiting inside it."
- "It hurt. God, it hurt."

Why It Fails:

- Artificial lyricism masking conceptual vacancy
- Emotional tautology—repetition replaces actual thought or development
- Second line rarely adds new information; just rephrases first line in adjacent terms

Flagging Trigger: If you write two consecutive sentences with mirrored structure, ask: Does the second line develop the first, or am I just creating rhythm?

1.11 MOOD-PROP NEGATION

Pattern: Character performs action immediately negated as meaningless

What It Looks Like:

- "She grabs the soy sauce she doesn't need."
- "He smoked a cigarette he didn't want."
- "She stared at a scratch he didn't make."
- "He drank tea he didn't really want."

Why It Fails:

- Signals complexity through subtraction, not concrete choice
- Pretends specificity while revealing nothing
- Becomes filler, avoiding real conflict

Flagging Trigger: If you write "[action] + [negation]," ask: Why is this character doing this? What does it reveal? If nothing, cut.

1.12 META-NARRATIVE INTRUSION

Pattern: Narration referencing story mechanics from within the story

What It Looks Like:

- "Scene's not over."
- "He waited for the next beat."
- "This was the real moment."
- "She knew the conversation wasn't finished."
- "The air felt like something was about to happen."

Why It Fails:

- Breaks immersion—makes reader conscious of author's hand
- Underlines narrative shape instead of letting it emerge

Flagging Trigger: If you write about "the scene" or "the moment" as structure, stop. You've left character POV. Reenter through action.

1.13 ATMOSPHERIC FRONT-LOADING

Pattern: Scene opens with weather, skyline, or architecture before character presence

What It Looks Like:

- "The New York skyline glowed through the penthouse window, casting neon over the glass table."
- "Rain traced the windows of the Tokyo apartment, the city lights flickering below."
- "The waves crashed against the shore outside, the moonlight pooling across the floor."

Why It Fails:

- Begins with set dressing, not story
- Creates distance when immediacy needed
- Mimics film language rather than character consciousness
- Filler buying time before committing to actual behavior

Flagging Trigger: If your first sentence could be read over a slow pan in a movie trailer, cut it. Start with character.

1.14 GRAVITATIONAL METAPHORS

Pattern: Physics language for emotional connection

What It Looks Like:

- "Pulled toward her."
- "Drawn to him."
- "Orbits around her."
- "The gravity between them."
- "Magnetic."

Why It Fails:

- Turns attraction into automatism—robs relationships of will
- Default metaphor for romantic connection
- Ignores psychology in favor of pseudo-science

Flagging Trigger: If you write attraction as physics, stop. Make it a choice.

1.15 SUSPENSION PHRASES

Pattern: "Hangs in the air" / "hangs between them"

What It Looks Like:

- "The words hang in the air."
- "The silence hangs between them."
- "The question hangs, unanswered."
- "The accusation hangs there."

Why It Fails:

- Repetition numbs impact
- "Hanging" creates stasis, not consequence
- Suggests unresolved tension without showing what happens next

Flagging Trigger: If you write "hangs," ask: What happens because of this silence/question/moment? Show aftermath, not suspended atmosphere.

1.16 IMPACT SIMILES

Pattern: "Like a [physical force]" for emotional shock

What It Looks Like:

- "Hit like a physical blow."
- "Hit like a punch to the gut."
- "Hit like a freight train."
- "Landed like a slap."
- "Knocked the air out of him."

Why It Fails:

- Relies on cliché rather than visceral description
- Makes every revelation feel identical
- Removes character-specific response

Flagging Trigger: If you write "like a blow," stop. Show the actual physical sensation instead.

1.17 RIPPLE/STILLNESS SIMILES

Pattern: Water imagery for emotional impact

What It Looks Like:

- "Like a stone dropped in still water."
- "Rippled through him."
- "Sent ripples through the room."
- "The stillness shattered."
- "Cracked the silence like glass."

Why It Fails:

- Dead simile universalized to meaninglessness
- No unique sensory or emotional anchor
- So common it's invisible

Flagging Trigger: If you write "like a stone" or "rippled through," cut it. Show impact directly.

1.18 PRECISION/CONTROL CLUSTER

Pattern: Overuse of clinical competence descriptors

What It Looks Like:

- "Surgical precision."
- "With practiced ease."
- "Economical movement."
- "Calculated."
- "Calibrated."
- "Methodical."
- "Clinical."
- "Exacting."

Why It Fails:

- Reduces character to competence performance
- Becomes shorthand for "impressive" without showing what's actually happening
- Flattens distinct characters into same cool efficiency

Flagging Trigger: If you describe action as "precise" or "surgical," ask: What does this actually look like? What's the specific movement?

1.19 QUALITY/TEXTURE DEFAULTS

Pattern: Same material metaphors for voice, tension, or restraint

What It Looks Like:

- "Velvet" (voice, darkness, threat)
- "Silk over steel"
- "Steel" (spine, voice, gaze, grip)
- "Iron" (control, grip, will)
- "Granite"
- "Marble"

Why It Fails:

- So overused they're invisible
- Every controlled character gets the same metallurgical description
- No longer creates sensory impression

Flagging Trigger: If you reach for steel/iron/velvet/silk, find a different texture entirely—or describe the actual sensation.

1.20 BLANK DESIRE STATEMENTS

Pattern: Desire expressed as appetite without psychological grounding

What It Looks Like:

- "He wanted her. God, he wanted her."
- "She needed him like air."
- "The wanting was unbearable."
- "He ached for her."
- "She craved him."

Why It Fails:

- Desire without motive reads as template—could apply to any character in any story
- Reduces complex desire to generic biological drive
- No differentiation between characters

Flagging Trigger: If you write "wanted her" or "needed him," ask: Wanted/needed what, specifically? For what purpose? What does this desire reveal?

1.21 ARTICULATION BY PROXY

Pattern: Claiming communication happened without showing content

What It Looks Like:

- "He gave her a look that said everything."
- "They didn't need words."
- "She knew what he meant."
- "The look they exchanged spoke volumes."
- "His expression said it all."

Why It Fails:

- Admits narrative laziness—writer doesn't know what's being communicated
- Pretends at intimacy while withholding actual subtext
- Breaks the contract with reader: if communication happens, we should understand its content

Flagging Trigger: If you write "a look that said" or "didn't need words," ask: What is actually being communicated here? Can I show the exchange?

1.22 HOLLOW RESTRAINT

Pattern: Describing containment without naming what's contained or what it costs

What It Looks Like:

- "He held it together."
- "She swallowed it down."
- "He kept it inside."
- "She bottled it up."
- "He locked it away."

Why It Fails:

- Vague abstraction of repression without psychological texture
- Generic across all characters—everyone "holds it together" identically
- What matters is what leaks when containment fails

Flagging Trigger: If you write about holding/containing emotion, ask: What exactly is being held? How is this character physically achieving restraint? What breaks if they stop?

1.23 AESTHETICIZED DAMAGE

Pattern: Stylized dysfunction as character shorthand

What It Looks Like:

- "He poured another drink he didn't need."
- "She hadn't slept in three days."
- "The city ate people like him alive."
- "Another sleepless night, another empty bottle."
- "She lived on coffee and cigarettes and spite."

Why It Fails:

- Romanticizes burnout and alienation as aesthetic rather than lived reality
- Substitutes darkness for depth
- Performs suffering without dramatizing what it costs

Flagging Trigger: If you write about drinking, sleeplessness, or self-destruction, ask: Am I showing what this costs, or am I using it as character decoration?

1.24 FAUX-INTELLECTUAL APHORISM

Pattern: Lines that sound profound but offer zero narrative content

What It Looks Like:

- "We are all just stories in the end."
- "Maybe love was the real war."
- "Sometimes, survival looks like surrender."
- "Pain is just love with nowhere to go."
- "The heart wants what it wants, even when it knows better."

Why It Fails:

- Performs insight without grounding in character experience
- Breaks tonal realism—no one thinks in quotable one-liners during actual emotional crisis
- Stops narrative momentum to deliver manufactured profundity

Flagging Trigger: If you write a line that sounds like it belongs on a motivational poster or could be retweeted as "deep thoughts," stop. Ask: Is this a real thought this specific character would have in this moment?

1.25 MISAPPLIED EPIC TONE

Pattern: Heightened language treating minor moments as climactic

What It Looks Like:

- "In that instant, something in him broke forever."
- "The world held its breath."
- "It was only a touch, but it changed everything."
- "Nothing would ever be the same."

Why It Fails:

- Every moment reads as climax—undermines proportion
- Sounds algorithmically "important" rather than earned
- Breaks psychological realism

Flagging Trigger: If you write "changed everything" or "broke forever," ask: Is this moment actually that big? If not, scale down.

1.26 ELEGANT VARIATION

Pattern: Cycling through synonyms or descriptors to avoid repeating a character's name

What It Looks Like:

- "the older man" / "the younger woman" rotating with names
- "the Japanese man" / "the dark-skinned woman" substituting for names
- "his lover" / "her partner" / "the other man" used interchangeably
- "the protagonist" / "the key player" / "the central figure"

Why It Fails:

- Draws attention to the writer avoiding repetition rather than to the scene
- Creates distance—readers register descriptors as narrative intrusion
- Flattens character into demographic marker or role
- Signals AI generation through mechanical synonym cycling

Flagging Trigger: If you've used a descriptor instead of a name, ask: Would I notice this rotation as a reader? Is the descriptor doing work (establishing POV, power dynamic, emotional distance), or am I just avoiding the name?

The Exception: Descriptors are valid when they reveal POV or shift. "The man who used to be her husband" is doing work. "The tall man" rotating with "[CHARACTER]" is not.

1.27 FALSE RANGE CONSTRUCTION

Pattern: "From X to Y" where X and Y aren't on the same measurable scale

What It Looks Like:

- "From the intimacy of their first kiss to the architecture of their silence"
- "From heartbreak to revolution"
- "From the weight of history to the lightness of her laugh"
- "From pain to transformation to power"

Why It Fails:

- Sounds comprehensive but means nothing
- No actual scale exists between the endpoints
- Borrowed from persuasive/promotional writing where vagueness is a feature
- Mimics profundity through syntactic shape rather than content

Flagging Trigger: If you write "from X to Y," ask: Can I identify a middle ground between these endpoints without switching to a different scale? If no, it's a false range. Cut it.

1.28 SUPERFICIAL ANALYSIS AS NARRATION

Pattern: Present participle phrases attached to sentences to editorialize meaning

What It Looks Like:

- "She left the room, highlighting her frustration."
- "He poured another drink, underscoring his exhaustion."
- "They sat in silence, reflecting the distance between them."
- "She touched his arm, emphasizing her concern."

Why It Fails:

- Narrator steps in to explain what the action means
- Removes reader's role in interpreting behavior
- The action should carry its own weight—if it doesn't, the action is wrong
- Classic AI tell: inanimate facts/events "highlighting" or "underscoring" things

Flagging Trigger: If you attach a participle phrase that interprets the action (highlighting, underscoring, reflecting, emphasizing, showcasing, symbolizing), delete it. The action either speaks for itself or needs to be rewritten so it does.

1.29 NEGATIVE PARALLELISM

Pattern: "Not only... but..." or "It's not about X, it's about Y" constructions

What It Looks Like:

- "It wasn't just the silence—it was everything the silence contained."
- "Not only had she lost him, but she had lost herself."
- "It's not about the money. It's about respect."
- "He didn't just leave. He erased himself."

Why It Fails:

- Performs profundity through syntactic opposition
- The second clause often restates the first in inflated terms
- Halts narrative momentum for rhetorical emphasis
- Overused in AI output as a depth-simulation device

Flagging Trigger: If you write "not only... but" or "it's not about X, it's about Y," ask: Is the second clause adding information, or just amplifying? Can I cut the construction and state the point directly?

1.30 SIMILE-AS-ADVERB

Pattern: "With [noun] of someone [verb]ing"

What It Looks Like:

- "With the grim determination of someone preparing for a siege."
- "With the weariness of someone who had explained this before."
- "With the caution of someone approaching a wild animal."
- "With the focus of someone defusing a bomb."

Why It Fails:

- Sounds like characterization but it's just a simile doing an adverb's job
- Invents a hypothetical person to describe the actual person's state

- Unnecessarily wordy—just describe the tone or behavior directly
- Claude loves this construction because it *feels* specific without requiring actual specificity

Flagging Trigger: If you write "with the [noun] of someone," stop. Ask: Can I just describe what they're actually doing or feeling? Do I need the imaginary siege-preparer?

1.31 TRAILING PARTICIPLE CONSTRUCTION

Pattern: [Main clause], [present participle phrase]—repeated until every sentence has the same trailing rhythm.

What It Looks Like:

- "Elara opened the box, her fingers trembling."
- "Inside was a necklace, the diamond pendant glimmering in the light."
- "She held it in the air, gazing at the luminous jewel."
- "He crossed the room, running a hand through his hair."
- "She sat down, pulling her knees to her chest."
- "He turned away, staring out the window."

Why It Fails:

- Creates monotonous sentence rhythm—every action gets the same syntactic shape
- Often produces simultaneous actions that aren't actually simultaneous ("She opened the door, stepping inside"—did she phase through it mid-swing?)
- Becomes a crutch for cramming extra detail into sentences without varying structure
- Gives prose a floaty, continuous quality where everything is happening at once in an endless "-ing" stream
- Three of these in a row and the reader is swimming in participles

The Compounding Problem: One trailing participle is fine. Two in a paragraph is noticeable. Three or more consecutive sentences with this structure and the prose starts to feel like it's being generated rather than written. AI defaults to this rhythm because it's syntactically safe and infinitely extensible.

Flagging Trigger: If you've written more than two sentences in a row ending with a participle phrase, stop. Vary the structure—lead with the participle, use a period and make it its own sentence, or cut the participle entirely and just describe the action directly.

QUICK-SCAN: CONSTRUCTIONS

Search Term	If Found
", then"	Rewrite as fluid motion or consequence
"something" + verb	Name what's actually happening
"silence" + stretches/hangs/sits	Show effect through behavior
"not [X], but [Y]"	Commit to what it is
"isn't quite"	Describe the gesture specifically
"hangs in the air"	Show consequence, not suspension
"like a blow/punch/freight train"	Show sensation directly
"like a stone" + water	Cut—dead metaphor
"finally"	Show who breaks first
triple noun/fragment sequence	Cut to what matters or integrate
"[Verb]. [Verb]. [Verb]."	Vary syntax
"And" / "But" sentence start	Use sparingly for earned emphasis
"Because [X]." fragment	Integrate or show through action
"surgical precision" / "practiced ease"	Show actual movement
"steel" / "iron" / "velvet" / "silk"	Find different texture
"wanted her/him" without object	Specify what's wanted and why
"a look that said" / "didn't need words"	Show the actual exchange
"held it together" / "swallowed it down"	Name what's being contained
"changed everything" / "broke forever"	Scale to proportion
weather/skyline as scene opener	Start with character
"from X to Y" (abstract)	Check if actual scale exists
"the older man" / "the younger woman"	Use names unless descriptor does work

participle + highlighting/underscoring	Delete editorial narration
"not only... but"	State directly or cut
"with the [noun] of someone"	Describe the actual behavior directly
", [verb]ing" / ", her [noun] [verb]ing"	Vary sentence structure—check for participle pile-up

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PART 2: WORDS AND PHRASES

Purpose

This section catalogs **specific words and phrases** that weaken prose through overuse, vagueness, or cliché. These are the building blocks of the structural problems in Part 1—the individual terms that signal lazy writing, generic emotion, or AI-generated filler.

Core Principle: If a word or phrase could appear unchanged across any character, any genre, any story—it's doing no work. Cut it.

2.1 PHYSICAL TELLS (EMOTION SUBSTITUTES)

These get used reflexively instead of actual interiority, psychology, or consequence. They flatten distinct characters into identical nervous systems.

Jaw/Face

- jaw tightens / clenches / sets / locks
- jaw works
- muscle jumps / ticks in jaw
- teeth grind

Throat/Breath

- throat works / bobs
- swallows hard / thickly
- breath catches / hitches / stutters
- breath punched out
- exhales slowly / shakily

- releases a breath [he/she] didn't know [he/she] was holding
- forgets to breathe

Eyes

- eyes darken / go dark
- pupils blown / blown wide
- gaze sharpens / hardens / softens
- something flickers in [his/her] eyes
- eyes search [his/her] face

Hands/Body

- hands curl into fists
- knuckles whiten
- fingers flex / twitch at [his/her] side
- hand flexes at side
- spine straightens / stiffens
- shoulders tense / drop
- goes very still
- freezes

Heart/Chest

- heart stutters / pounds / races
- chest tightens / aches
- something cracks / shifts / loosens in [his/her] chest

Why These Fail: Autonomic responses don't differentiate emotion. Every character ends up with the same body language regardless of psychology, history, or coping patterns.

2.2 VAGUE INTERIORITY PLACEHOLDERS

These substitute for naming actual emotions or stakes.

- something in [him/her] shifts / breaks / cracks / loosens / changes
- something unnameable
- something like [emotion]
- the weight of [X] settles / presses / lands
- a wave of [emotion] crashes / washes over
- [emotion] curls / coils in [his/her] stomach
- feels it in [his/her] bones

- the words hang between them
- the silence stretches / sits heavy / presses
- the air thickens / shifts / changes
- the room feels smaller

Why These Fail: "Something" signals the writer knows an effect occurred but can't specify what. These phrases tell that change happened without showing how.

2.3 DEFAULT EMOTION DESCRIPTORS

Overused intensity markers that have lost all specificity.

- raw
- visceral
- primal
- bone-deep
- soul-deep
- marrow-deep
- paper-thin (control, patience, composure)
- gossamer-thin
- razor-thin
- threadbare
- frayed edges
- worn thin
- stretched to breaking

Why These Fail: These words affect intensity without specifying quality. "Raw" anger and "raw" grief and "raw" desire all collapse into the same vague urgency.

2.4 TRANSITION / BEAT PLACEHOLDERS

Empty time markers simulating pacing without creating it.

- for a long moment
- for a beat
- for a suspended moment
- after a moment
- a pause, then
- finally (as transition)
- when [he/she] speaks, [his/her] voice is [adjective]

- the silence that follows is [adjective]

Why These Fail: These phrases label time passing rather than showing what happens during it. They're stage directions, not lived experience.

2.5 DIALOGUE TAGS AND MODIFIERS

Adverbial crutches that tell tone instead of embedding it.

Adverbs After Said/Asked

- softly
- quietly
- carefully
- finally
- slowly
- flatly
- evenly
- roughly

Voice Descriptors

- voice drops
- voice tightens
- voice goes flat
- voice breaks
- voice hardens
- voice softens
- pitched low
- barely above a whisper
- deceptively soft / mild
- deliberately light
- falsely casual
- too casual

Why These Fail: If the dialogue needs an adverb to convey tone, the dialogue itself isn't doing its job.

2.6 GAZE / LOOK DESCRIPTORS

Overused shorthand for unspoken communication.

- assessing
- appraising
- cataloguing
- tracking
- watchful
- guarded
- shuttered
- unreadable
- inscrutable
- too knowing
- seeing too much

Why These Fail: These create the impression of depth without specifying what's actually being communicated or withheld.

2.7 PRECISION / CONTROL CLUSTER

Clinical competence descriptors that flatten characters into identical efficiency.

- surgical precision
- precision (overuse in general)
- with practiced ease
- with practiced efficiency
- economical movement(s)
- deliberate and controlled
- calculated
- calibrated
- methodical
- clinical
- exacting
- meticulous

Why These Fail: These substitute "impressive" for specific action. Every controlled character ends up sounding the same.

2.8 COMPETENCE PORN DESCRIPTORS

Shorthand for capability that tells rather than shows.

- effortless
- seamless
- fluid
- graceful economy
- wasted no movement
- efficient brutality
- quiet competence
- easy confidence
- contained power
- coiled energy
- deceptive stillness

Why These Fail: These describe the impression of competence rather than the specific actions that create it.

2.9 QUALITY / TEXTURE DEFAULTS

The same material metaphors applied to every controlled or dangerous character.

- velvet (voice, darkness, threat)
- silk (over steel, voice)
- steel (spine, voice, gaze, grip)
- iron (control, grip, will)
- granite
- marble

Why These Fail: So overused they're invisible. Find different textures or describe the actual sensation.

2.10 TEMPERATURE METAPHORS

Oldest affect shorthand—drains emotional register to binary hot/cold.

- cold (voice, gaze, tone)
- frozen
- ice in [his/her] veins
- blood ran cold
- warmth spread through
- heat pooled low
- heat between them

- fire licked up [his/her] spine
- something molten
- cold settled in [his/her] bones

Why These Fail: Temperature is the most generic descriptor for emotion. It narrows the entire emotional spectrum to two options.

2.11 IMPACT / FORCE PHRASES

Overused shorthand for emotional shock.

- hit like a physical blow
- hit like a punch to the gut
- hit like a freight train
- landed like a blow
- struck like a slap
- knocked the air out of [him/her]
- felt like a gut punch

Why These Fail: Makes every revelation feel identical. Removes character-specific response.

2.12 RIPPLE / STILLNESS PHRASES

Dead water imagery for emotional impact.

- like a stone dropped in still water
- rippled through [him/her]
- sent ripples through
- the stillness shattered
- cracked the silence like glass

Why These Fail: So common they're invisible. No unique sensory or emotional anchor.

2.13 BREAKING / CRACKING METAPHORS

Overused for emotional transformation.

- something cracked open

- split [him/her] open
- broke something loose
- shattered something [he/she] didn't know was fragile
- fractured the moment
- splintered
- hairline fractures
- fault lines
- cracks in the foundation

Why These Fail: Every emotional shift becomes the same structural failure. No differentiation between types of change.

2.14 ANCHOR / TETHER / GROUNDING METAPHORS

Default metaphors for emotional stability or dependence.

Banned terms:

- anchored [him/her]
- tethered [him/her] to [X]
- grounded [him/her]
- the only thing keeping [him/her] [grounded/present/sane]
- held [him/her] in place
- moored
- centered
- rooted
- kept [him/her] tethered
- was [his/her] anchor

Why These Fail: Turns emotional stability into boat metaphor. Every relationship becomes a dock. Connection is passive—something that happens to characters rather than something they choose.

2.15 EDGE / PRECIPICE METAPHORS

Overused for emotional instability.

- on the edge of something

- teetering on the precipice
- one wrong word from [falling/breaking/shattering]
- barely holding on
- hanging by a thread

Why These Fail: Abstract geography substituting for specific psychological state.

2.16 SOUND / SILENCE PHRASES

Anthropomorphized absence.

- the words fell into silence
- swallowed by the quiet
- the silence swallowed it
- deafening silence
- silence roared
- the quiet pressed in
- hangs in the air

Why These Fail: Treats silence as an actor rather than showing its effect on characters.

2.17 TIME / MOMENT PHRASES

Pseudo-cinematic pause language.

- time stretched
- the moment crystallized
- suspended in amber
- frozen in place
- the world narrowed to
- everything else fell away
- the world held its breath

Why These Fail: Evokes camera, not consciousness. Tells reader when to feel tension rather than creating it.

2.18 PERMISSION / ALLOWANCE CONSTRUCTIONS

Phrases signaling emotional restraint releasing.

- allowed [himself/herself] to [verb]
- let [himself/herself] [verb]
- gave [himself/herself] permission to
- permitted [himself/herself] the luxury of
- finally let go of

Why These Fail: Labels release rather than showing what changes when restraint drops.

2.19 REALIZATION / UNDERSTANDING PHRASES

Shorthand for mental shift.

- it clicked into place
- the pieces slotted together
- understanding dawned
- clarity crashed over [him/her]
- the truth of it settled
- landed with the force of
- crystallized

Why These Fail: Tells that realization happened rather than showing the thought process or consequence.

2.20 DANGER / THREAT DESCRIPTORS

Default vocabulary for menacing characters.

- lethal grace
- predatory stillness
- coiled to strike
- dangerous edge
- barely contained violence
- quiet menace
- soft threat
- the promise of violence

Why These Fail: Every dangerous character gets the same predator-animal vocabulary. No differentiation.

2.21 SPACE / PRESENCE PHRASES

Clichés for charismatic characters.

- commanded the room
- filled the space
- sucked the air out of the room
- dominated the space
- presence that demanded attention
- gravity (as charisma metaphor)
- magnetic
- impossible to ignore

Why These Fail: Tell that someone is impressive rather than showing what they do that creates that impression.

2.22 INTIMACY / CONNECTION PHRASES

Default vocabulary for emotional closeness.

- the space between them
- closed the distance
- breached [his/her] defenses
- slipped past [his/her] guard
- got under [his/her] skin
- burrowed in
- took root
- settled into the cracks

Why These Fail: Treats intimacy as infiltration rather than choice. Same military/fortress metaphor for every relationship.

2.23 POSSESSION / CLAIMING PHRASES

Overused for romantic intensity.

- staked a claim
- marked [him/her]

- branded into
- written into [his/her] skin
- carved into [his/her] bones

Why These Fail: Same branding metaphor for every intense connection. No differentiation between types of possession or why it matters.

2.24 EMOTIONAL STATE SHORTHAND

Vocabulary for repression that tells rather than shows.

- tamped down
- locked down
- held in check
- barely leashed
- tightly controlled
- white-knuckled control
- iron grip on [emotion]
- ruthlessly suppressed
- shoved down
- compartmentalized

Why These Fail: Labels containment without showing the mechanism, cost, or what leaks when it fails.

2.25 TRANSITION VERBS (OVERUSE)

Verbs that describe change without specifying what changed.

- shifted
- settled
- flickered
- softened
- hardened
- sharpened
- gentled
- eased
- tightened
- loosened

Why These Fail: These become invisible through repetition. They describe that something changed without showing the change.

2.26 FAUX-EDGY BANTER

Dialogue patterns that substitute trope familiarity for actual chemistry.

- "You're such a menace."
- "You're impossible."
- "You're trouble."
- "You're the worst."
- "You're insufferable."
- "You're ridiculous."
- "You're going to be the death of me."
- "[says something]" "You love it."

Why These Fail: Tonally juvenile. Derives from fandom banter tropes with no psychological grounding. Every character sounds identical regardless of background or dynamic.

2.27 CINEMATIC WALLPAPER

Atmospheric filler that delays character presence.

- light spills / pools / catches
- shadows play across
- the skyline stretches
- floor-to-ceiling windows
- casting [X] in sharp relief
- neon glow
- ozone smell
- the city hummed

Why These Fail: Set dressing before story. Mimics film language rather than character consciousness.

2.28 DESCRIPTION CLICHÉS

Overused body part descriptors.

- orbs / pools (for eyes)
- alabaster / porcelain / ivory (for skin)
- mane (for hair)
- column of neck
- delicate wrists
- sharp planes of [his] face
- the line of [his] jaw
- broad shoulders
- lean muscle

Why These Fail: So common they're invisible. Create no specific visual impression.

2.29 DOMESTIC / CLOTHING FILLER

Details that pad scenes without narrative function.

Clothing

- shorts
- tees / t-shirts
- sweats / sweatpants
- leggings
- jeans (unless plot-relevant)
- thin cotton / soft cotton
- sleeves rolled to the elbow

Activities

- dishwashing
- folding laundry
- reading books (as filler)
- drinking tea / coffee (as filler)
- flipping through magazines
- wiping counters
- tidying

Why These Fail: Fake intimacy signal suggesting realism but stalling momentum. Replaces decision, conflict, or risk with neutral busywork.

2.30 RELIGIOUS EXPRESSIONS

Exclamations that break voice and default to generic intensity.

- Oh God
- Oh my God
- God yes / God no
- Jesus
- Christ
- Lord

Why These Fail: Reflexive intensity markers that tell nothing about character. Universal default rather than character-specific expression.

2.31 ENDING CLICHÉS

Phrases that close scenes with false profundity rather than consequence.

- And for now, that was enough.
- It was a start.
- They would figure it out. Somehow.
- Nothing would ever be the same.
- Everything had changed.

Why These Fail: Summary posing as closure. Labels the emotional meaning rather than letting it emerge from action.

2.32 MISCELLANEOUS HIGH-FREQUENCY

Other overused terms that signal AI-generated or generic prose.

- cut through the noise
- sliced through
- pierced through
- wormed its way into
- clawed its way up
- fought its way to the surface
- threatened to spill over
- barely contained
- held at bay
- the architecture of [anything]
- the geometry of [anything]

- the calculus of [anything]
- the mathematics of [relationship/emotion]
- the grammar of [intimacy/violence]

Why These Fail: Pseudo-intellectual framing that performs analysis rather than showing character experience.

2.33 AI VOCABULARY CLUSTER

These words are disproportionately overrepresented in AI-generated text. Their presence doesn't automatically indicate AI, but clusters of them signal regression to statistically common phrasing rather than specific, character-grounded language.

Overused Abstract Nouns

- tapestry (figurative)
- landscape (figurative)
- interplay
- intricacies
- nuance / nuanced
- multifaceted
- dynamics
- framework
- paradigm

Overused Verbs

- delve / delves / delving
- foster / fostering
- garner / garnered / garnering
- underscore / underscoring
- showcase / showcasing
- highlight / highlighting (as narrator editorializing)
- emphasize / emphasizing
- reflect / reflecting (as narrator editorializing)
- align / aligns / aligning
- enhance / enhancing
- navigate (emotions, relationships)
- unpack (ideas, feelings)

Overused Adjectives

- pivotal
- crucial
- vital
- vibrant
- intricate
- nuanced
- multifaceted
- profound
- compelling
- poignant
- evocative
- visceral
- palpable

Overused Adverbs

- seemingly
- arguably
- notably
- importantly
- ultimately
- fundamentally
- inherently
- undeniably
- understandably

Why These Fail: They're statistically common in the training data, so AI defaults to them. They signal "important-sounding" without being specific. In narrative prose, they flatten voice into generic literary register.

2.34 NARRATOR-AS-ANALYST PHRASES

These phrases turn narration into editorial commentary, explaining significance rather than dramatizing it.

Banned Constructions:

- [action], highlighting [interpretation]
- [action], underscoring [meaning]
- [action], reflecting [theme]
- [action], emphasizing [significance]
- [action], showcasing [quality]

- [action], symbolizing [abstraction]
- [action], illustrating [point]
- [action], demonstrating [trait]

Why These Fail: The narrator steps outside the scene to tell the reader what something means. If the action requires interpretation, the action itself is underwritten.

2.35 LEGACY/IMPORTANCE PUFFERY

These phrases inflate significance through assertion rather than demonstration. Rare in good fiction, ubiquitous in AI output.

Banned Phrases:

- stands as a testament to
- serves as a reminder of
- a testament to
- enduring legacy
- lasting legacy
- lasting impact
- indelible mark
- deeply rooted
- profound heritage
- steadfast dedication
- plays a vital/pivotal/crucial role
- of paramount importance
- cannot be overstated

Why These Fail: These tell the reader something matters without showing why. In fiction, significance is earned through consequence, not declared through diction.

2.36 PROMOTIONAL/BROCHURE LANGUAGE

These phrases derive from travel writing, marketing copy, and promotional materials. They appear in AI output when describing places, experiences, or qualities.

Banned Phrases:

- nestled (unless literal geography)
- in the heart of

- boasts a
- stunning [anything]
- breathtaking [anything]
- continues to captivate
- rich tapestry of
- vibrant culture/community/scene
- bustling
- picturesque
- idyllic

Why These Fail: These are advertising words. They tell the reader to be impressed rather than creating the impression through specific detail.

2.37 FAMILIARITY / ROUTINE CLUSTER

These words gesture at established patterns without specifying what those patterns are.

Banned terms/phrases:

- familiar
- usual
- rhythm (as routine metaphor)
- routine
- ritual (unspecified)
- familiar rhythm
- usual routine
- familiar ritual
- daily ritual
- comfortable routine
- their usual rhythm
- the familiar routine of

Why These Fail: Placeholders for actual detail. "Their familiar ritual" tells you nothing. *What* ritual? Morning coffee? A specific argument? Sex on Sundays? These words feel concrete but are completely vague. If the ritual matters, name it. If it doesn't, cut the reference.

2.38 TIME-SKIP FILLERS

Transitions for people who don't want to write transitions.

Banned phrases:

- passed in a blur
- the next few weeks flew by
- time slipped away
- before [he/she] knew it
- lost track of time
- the days blended together
- time lost all meaning
- [time period] came and went

Why These Fail: These skip time without earning the skip or showing what filled it. "The next month passed in a blur" is the narrative equivalent of "and then some stuff happened." Either the time matters—in which case, show it—or it doesn't, in which case just cut to the next scene without announcing that you're skipping.

QUICK-SCAN: WORDS AND PHRASES

Search Term	Action
jaw	Replace with character-specific tell
throat	Replace with visible struggle
breath + hitch/catch/release	Delete or replace
something + shifts/breaks/changes	Name what's actually happening
raw	Name the actual emotion
carefully	Show caution through behavior
finally	Show who breaks first
weight of	Show consequence through reaction
for a moment/beat	Delete or show action
silence + stretches/hangs/sits	Show effect through behavior
like a blow	Show physical sensation directly

the need	Specify what character wants
meets (in intimacy)	Show who acts on whom
doesn't move	End on action or cut earlier
Oh God / Jesus / Christ	Delete
guttural	Replace with rough/torn/low
surgical / precision	Show actual movement
steel / iron / velvet	Find different texture
And for now, that was enough	Cut—find actual ending beat
delve / tapestry / landscape	Replace with specific language
highlighting / underscoring	Delete editorial narration
pivotal / crucial / vital	Earn importance through action
nestled / boasts / vibrant	Delete promotional language
grounded / anchored / tethered / rooted	Find different stability metaphor or show through action
familiar / usual / rhythm / routine / ritual	Specify the actual pattern or cut
passed in a blur / flew by / slipped away	Cut to next scene or show the time

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PART 3: GUIDELINES

Purpose

This section provides the **operational framework** for applying Parts 1 and 2. It explains why these bans exist, what to do instead, and how to systematically check your work.

Core Principle: Every banned element shares one root cause—substituting form for content, decoration for precision, or familiar rhythm for earned meaning. The corrective is always the same: be specific, be embodied, show consequence.

3.1 THE ROOT PROBLEM

All banned constructions, words, and phrases fail for the same reasons:

They Simulate Rather Than Create

- Rhythm that sounds literary but carries no meaning
- Gestures that look like emotion but specify nothing
- Metaphors that feel poetic but clarify nothing

They Are Interchangeable

- Could appear in any story, any genre, any character
- Reveal nothing specific about this person in this moment
- Function as placeholder until the writer figures out what's actually happening

They Tell Rather Than Show

- Label that emotion occurred rather than dramatizing it
- Announce that time passed rather than showing what filled it
- Declare that something changed rather than making the change visible

They Default to Familiar

- Reach for the first phrase that comes to mind
- Rely on reader recognition of trope rather than earned response
- Substitute genre convention for character-specific behavior

The Accumulation Principle

No single banned element makes prose bad. One "jaw tightens" is fine. One trailing participle is fine. One "something shifted" might even be the right choice in context.

The problem is accumulation.

When the same constructions, the same physical tells, the same vague interiority placeholders appear over and over—across characters, across scenes, regardless of context—the prose flattens. It stops feeling like a specific story about specific people and starts feeling like it was assembled from a bag of interchangeable parts.

This is the actual AI tell. Not any single word or phrase, but the *density of defaults*. AI writing sounds like AI writing because it reaches for the statistically common option every time. It

doesn't know to vary. It doesn't know that one character's stress response should look different from another's. It doesn't know that the third "silence stretched between them" in a chapter has lost all power. It just keeps generating the highest-probability completion.

Human writers fall into the same trap—reaching for familiar constructions on autopilot, defaulting to the first phrase that comes to mind. The result is identical: prose that reads as generated rather than written.

The Test:

When you catch a banned element, don't just ask "is this bad?" Ask:

- How many times have I used this in the last ten pages?
- Have I used it for multiple characters interchangeably?
- Is this the first appearance (possibly fine) or the fifth (definitely a pattern)?

A single "the weight of it settled in his chest" might work. The third one in a chapter means you're leaning on a crutch.

The Corollary:

This also means witch-hunting individual constructions is pointless. Someone who flags every em-dash or every "And" sentence-start as "AI writing" has missed the point. The question isn't whether a construction appears—it's whether it appears *reflexively, repeatedly, and interchangeably*.

Density. Pattern. Accumulation. That's what to watch for.

3.2 THE CORRECTIVE FRAMEWORK

When you catch a banned element, apply these questions:

For Physical Tells

Ask: How does *this specific character* show this emotion? What's their particular outlet—displacement activity, speech pattern change, postural shift?

For Vague Interiority

Ask: What is actually happening? What would an observer see? What would the character physically feel or specifically think?

For Metaphors

Ask: Does this comparison clarify or decorate? Does the vehicle share actual properties with the tenor, or does it just sound good?

For Dialogue Tags

Ask: Can the line carry its own tone? If I remove the modifier, does the reader still understand how it's delivered?

For Transitions

Ask: What happens during this pause? Who breaks first? What's the cost of the waiting?

For Endings

Ask: What action, decision, or consequence closes this beat? What changes because of what just happened?

3.3 WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

Instead of Generic Physical Tells

- Identify each character's specific stress responses
- Tie physical behavior to established psychology
- Show displacement activities that reveal coping patterns
- Let the body do something that advances the scene

Instead of Vague Emotion Words

- Name the specific emotion: anger, fear, grief, shame, desire, relief
- Show the thought pattern that accompanies the feeling
- Demonstrate the behavioral consequence of the state
- Reveal what the character wants to do but can't or won't

Instead of Dead Metaphors

- Describe the sensation directly
- Ground comparison in the character's specific frame of reference
- Cut the metaphor entirely if direct description works better
- Test: does this image clarify or just decorate?

Instead of Atmospheric Front-Loading

- Start with character in action or decision
- Introduce environment through character perception, not camera pan
- Let setting emerge from what the character notices and why
- Anchor atmosphere in sensory detail that matters to the scene

Instead of Stillness Endings

- End on a micro-action that crystallizes the emotional state
- Close with dialogue that shifts the dynamic
- Cut the scene earlier—before the false profundity
- Let consequence land rather than announcing that it landed

Instead of Echo-Line Poetics

- If the second line doesn't add information, cut it
- Combine into single sentence with actual movement
- Escalate, complicate, or contradict—don't just rephrase
- Trust single statements to carry weight

3.4 PRE-DRAFT PROTOCOL

Before writing any scene, confirm these commitments:

Structural:

- [ ] I will vary sentence rhythm—no mechanical "X, then Y" patterns
- [ ] I will not rely on triple-beat lists or staccato fragments for false emphasis
- [ ] I will start with character presence, not atmospheric establishing shots
- [ ] I will end on action, decision, or consequence—not stillness or summary

Language:

- [ ] I will use no adverbs on dialogue tags
- [ ] I will not use "something" as an emotion placeholder
- [ ] I will not describe silence/air/atmosphere as an active force
- [ ] I will name specific emotions rather than "raw," "weight," or "need"

Physical Description:

- [ ] Each character has distinct physical tells for tension, desire, and restraint
- [ ] I will not default to jaw/throat/hand clichés

- [ ] Breathing only matters if it changes scene tempo or power dynamic

Metaphor:

- [ ] No gravitational language for attraction
- [ ] No temperature as emotion shorthand
- [ ] No dead similes (stone in water, physical blow, hangs in air)
- [ ] Every comparison must clarify, not decorate

3.5 MID-DRAFT FLAGGING PROTOCOL

When you catch yourself writing a banned element, stop immediately and redirect:

If You Write...	Stop and Ask...
", then"	Does this sequence reveal psychology, or am I just choreographing?
"something"	What exactly is happening?
"silence stretches/hangs"	What is the effect on who?
"not X, but Y"	What is this actually? Can I commit?
adverb after "said"	Can the line carry its own tone?
"voice drops/tightens"	Can I show this through rhythm or action?
jaw/throat/hand tension	How does THIS character show restraint?
"finally"	Who yields first? What breaks the stalemate?
"raw"	What is the actual emotion?
"carefully"	Why? What would happen if they weren't careful?
"like a blow"	What does this actually feel like in the body?
"need" without object	Need for what? From whom? Why?
weather/skyline opening	Where is the character? What are they doing?
domestic activity	Does this create friction, or am I padding?
"changed everything"	Is this moment actually that big?

3.6 POST-DRAFT REVISION PROTOCOL

Systematic search-and-correct process:

Phase 1: Structural Patterns

Search: ", then" / "something [verb]" / "silence [verb]" / "not X, but Y" / "hangs in the air" **Action:** Rewrite every instance per guidelines

Phase 2: Dialogue

Search: "said/asked" + adverb / "[voice] drops/tightens/breaks" / "isn't quite" **Action:** Remove modifiers; embed tone in content

Phase 3: Physical Description

Search: jaw / throat / hand + tension / exhale / breath + release / "pupils blown" **Action:** Replace with character-specific responses

Phase 4: Temporal/Transition

Search: "for a moment/beat" / "finally" / "something shifts/breaks/changes" **Action:** Delete or replace with concrete action

Phase 5: Emotion Words

Search: raw / carefully / "weight of" / "the need" **Action:** Name specific emotion or show through behavior

Phase 6: Sentence Patterns

Search: Sentences starting with And/But / standalone "Because" / verb triplets **Action:** Vary rhythm; integrate fragments

Phase 7: Metaphors

Search: "like a stone" / "like a blow" / pull/draw/orbit / hot/cold / "hangs in" **Action:** Cut or replace with direct description

Phase 8: Endings

Search: "doesn't move" / "still in hand" / "doesn't say anything" / "And for now" **Action:** End on action, decision, or consequence

Phase 9: Openings/Filler

Search: Scene-opening weather/skyline / domestic activities / sensory lists / "the city hummed" **Action:** Start with character; cut busywork; trim decoration

Phase 10: Intensity

Search: "changed everything" / "broke forever" / "the world held its breath" **Action:** Scale to proportion; show specific consequence

Phase 11: AI Vocabulary

Search: delve / tapestry / landscape / pivotal / crucial / vibrant / highlighting / underscoring **Action:** Replace with specific, character-grounded language

Phase 12: Elegant Variation

Search: "the older man" / "the younger woman" / descriptor cycling **Action:** Use names unless descriptor does specific work

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3.7 THE FINAL TEST

Before any piece is complete, run these checks:

Specificity Test

- Could any line appear unchanged in a different story with different characters?
- If yes, it's not specific enough. Rewrite.

Interchangeability Test

- Could this physical tell / metaphor / ending belong to any character?
- If yes, it's not character-specific. Rewrite.

Consequence Test

- Does something change because of this scene / beat / line?
- If nothing changes, the scene isn't done.

Decoration Test

- Does this metaphor / description / sensory detail clarify or just ornament?
- If it only ornaments, cut it.

Earned Test

- Has this emotional beat been built to, or am I announcing it?
- If announced, either build the foundation or scale down.

3.8 WHEN RULES CONFLICT

Specificity vs. Brevity

- Specificity wins. A longer line that does work beats a shorter line that decorates.

Character Voice vs. Ban List

- If a specific character would genuinely use a banned term in dialogue, flag it and use sparingly with clear justification.
- Narration has no such excuse.

Rhythm vs. Clarity

- Clarity wins. A clunky sentence that communicates beats a smooth sentence that obscures.

Convention vs. Precision

- Precision wins. An unfamiliar construction that fits beats a familiar one that doesn't.

3.9 THE OPERATING PRINCIPLE

This guide is not about restriction—it's about clearing space for the story that actually matters.

Every banned element is a shortcut that prevents the writer from doing the harder, better work of:

- Figuring out what's actually happening
- Understanding how this specific character would respond

- Building tension through structure rather than announcing it through diction
- Trusting the reader to feel what's been earned rather than being told what to feel

The bans exist to force precision. The precision serves the story.

3.10 THE AI PATTERN PROBLEM

Beyond bad craft, many banned patterns are identifiable AI tells. This matters for two reasons:

1. Detection Risk Readers increasingly recognize AI-generated prose. Patterns that signal AI origin break immersion and undermine trust in the narrative voice.

2. The Underlying Failure Is the Same AI defaults to statistically common patterns because it lacks specific knowledge of character, scene, and consequence. When human writers use the same patterns, they're making the same error—substituting generic rhythm for specific meaning.

The AI detection problem and the craft problem share a root cause: regression to the mean. AI writing sounds like AI writing because it's averaging across millions of texts. Human writing that sounds like AI writing is doing the same thing unconsciously.

The corrective is identical: Be specific. Ground every description in character perception. Make every gesture do work. Let consequence emerge from action rather than being announced by narration.

3.11 THE ELEGANT VARIATION TRAP

AI cycles through synonyms to avoid repetition, producing constructions like:

- "the protagonist" → "the key player" → "the central figure"
- "[CHARACTER]" → "the older man" → "her husband" → "the architect"

This is mechanical avoidance, not craft.

The Rule: Use names unless the descriptor is doing specific work:

- Establishing POV ("the man she used to love")
- Marking emotional distance ("the stranger wearing her husband's face")
- Shifting power dynamic ("the woman he'd underestimated")

If the descriptor is just avoiding the name, use the name.

3.12 NARRATOR DISTANCE

AI narration tends toward analysis—explaining what things mean rather than dramatizing them. This produces constructions like:

- "She closed the door, highlighting her need for space."
- "He laughed, a sound that underscored his discomfort."

The narrator is stepping outside the scene to editorialize.

The Rule: Narration should remain inside character perception or inside the scene's physical reality. The moment narration starts explaining significance, it has become essay rather than fiction.

If an action needs interpretation, either:

1. The action is underwritten and needs to be more specific
2. The interpretation belongs in character interiority, not narrator commentary
3. The interpretation should be cut—trust the reader

PART 4: EROTICA-SPECIFIC GUIDELINES

Purpose

This section governs **explicit sexual content**. It builds on Parts 1-3 but addresses the specific failure modes of erotic writing: euphemism, abstraction, cartoonish physicality, and trope substitution for psychology.

Core Principle: Erotic scenes must be embodied, realistic, and psychologically grounded. Sex is action—it follows the same rules as any other scene. Something must change. Consequence must be visible. Character voice must remain distinct.

4.1 LANGUAGE BANS

Euphemisms

These sanitize or romanticize body parts and functions. They signal discomfort with explicitness or default to romance-novel convention.

Banned terms:

- slick (as noun)
- spend
- release (as noun for orgasm)
- essence
- fluids
- cream
- core
- length
- folds
- womanhood
- member
- sex (as noun for genitals)
- center
- heat (as noun for genitals)
- entrance
- channel
- sheath

Romance Fluff

Transcendence framing that aestheticizes sex into abstraction.

Banned phrases:

- joined as one
- two become one
- soul-touched
- souls entwined
- made love (as euphemism for fucked)
- completed [him/her]
- transcendent
- sacred union

4.2 RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE BANS

Religious exclamations and metaphors that default to generic intensity or impose reverence framing on intimacy.

Exclamations

- Oh God
- Oh my God
- God yes / God no
- Jesus
- Christ
- Lord
- Dear God
- God help [me/him/her]

Metaphors

- worship
- worshipped
- altar
- sacred
- divine
- prayer
- scripture
- communion
- reverence
- devotion (in religious sense)
- blessing

Why These Fail: Religious language imposes a reverence frame that aestheticizes rather than embodies. It also defaults to generic intensity rather than character-specific expression.

4.3 SWEAT AND PERSPIRATION BANS

Sweat description becomes filler that substitutes for actual tension, exertion, or heat.

Banned terms/phrases:

- forehead sheen
- damp curls
- skin slick (with sweat)
- beading sweat
- glistening
- humid
- clammy
- perspiration

- sweat-slicked
- dewy

Use Instead: Heat, tremor, breath, muscle tension. Wetness in erotic scenes comes from arousal, come, lube, spit—not decorative perspiration.

4.4 PORNO TROPE BANS

Cartoonish physicality that substitutes for realistic sex.

Motion Verbs

- slamming
- impaling
- pistoning
- pounding (as default rhythm)
- jackhammering
- drilling
- plowing

Vocalization

- screamed (during orgasm)
- screaming in ecstasy
- shrieked
- wailed
- howled

Fluid Exaggeration

- rivers of come
- endless streams
- flooded
- drenched (in come)
- gallons
- impossible volumes

Cliché Phrases

- buried to the hilt
- balls deep (as the only depth descriptor)
- smelled of sex

- tasted of salt
- the musky scent of arousal
- her arousal evident

Kissing Clichés

- tongues battling for dominance
- tongues dueling
- all teeth and tongue
- devoured [his/her] mouth

Touch Clichés

- tracing patterns
- tracing lazy circles
- featherlight touches
- whisper-soft
- butterfly kisses

4.5 VOCAL DESCRIPTOR BANS

Overused sound tags that flatten distinct voices.

Banned terms:

- guttural
- keening
- mewling
- whimpering (overuse)
- breathy moan
- grunted
- growled (as default male vocalization)

Use Instead: rough, torn, low, broken, caught, strangled, bitten-off. Or describe the actual sound rather than labeling it.

4.6 AFTERMATH CLICHÉ BANS

Post-climax descriptors that have lost all meaning through overuse.

Banned terms:

- spent
- ruined
- wrecked
- undone
- boneless
- shattered
- destroyed
- broken (in pleasurable sense)
- liquefied

Why These Fail: These tell that intensity occurred rather than showing the specific state of the body or mind after.

4.7 POSITION AND MOTION BANS

Physical impossibilities and lazy shorthand.

Anatomical Implausibility

- pinning wrists above head (in positions where leverage doesn't work)
- constant hip-gripping while thrusting (physically impossible to maintain grip + leverage)
- one-thrust full penetration (with any significant size)
- standing sex without support (wall, counter, furniture, or being held)

Intensity Shorthand

- gripped hard enough to bruise (as default intensity marker—actual bruising requires abuse-level force)
- nails drawing blood (unless intentional and addressed)
- bit hard enough to mark (unless intentional and addressed)

Lazy Choreography

- fisting sheets (overused)
- gripping headboard (overused)
- arching off the bed (overused)
- toes curling (overused)
- head thrown back (overused)

4.8 DARK ROMANCE TROPE BANS

Power dynamic clichés that substitute for actual psychology.

Banned framings:

- Daddy/dom aesthetic or pet names
- humiliation play (unless explicitly established as character dynamic)
- alpha-asshole framing (dominance as swagger rather than psychology)
- clingy/groveling partner framing (need as pathetic rather than human)
- possession as ownership rather than devotion
- "teaching" or "training" framing without consent context
- punishment framing for pleasure

4.9 RACE AND ETHNICITY BANS

Fetishization language that reduces characters to racial/ethnic tropes.

Banned terms:

- exotic
- chocolate
- ebony
- caramel
- mocha
- coffee
- any food comparison for skin
- savage
- primal (in racial context)
- submissive Asian
- stoic Oriental
- dragon lady
- geisha
- lotus blossom
- any animal comparison for racialized features

Banned framings:

- martial arts / monk / samurai metaphors for Asian men (unless literal context)
- "jungle" or "wild" framing for Black characters
- "spicy" or "fiery" framing for Latina characters
- any framing that reduces a character to racial stereotype

4.10 ABSTRACT CONCEPT BANS

Philosophy and analysis language that breaks embodiment.

Banned in erotic dialogue:

- structure
- anchor
- submission (as abstract concept)
- dominance (as abstract concept)
- power exchange
- dynamic
- connection
- intimacy (as spoken word during sex)
- any therapy-speak or relationship-analysis language during the act

Why These Fail: Characters in the middle of sex don't narrate the psychology of what they're doing. They act. Analysis belongs in meta-discussion, not in-scene dialogue.

4.11 POSITIVE GUIDANCE: LANGUAGE

Plain Terms (Use These)

- pussy
- cock
- clit
- come (noun and verb)
- precome
- wetness
- wet
- hard
- inside
- deep
- full

Embodied Detail (Lean Into)

- hips tilt / shift / roll / cant
- thighs tremble / shake / tighten
- breath trips / catches / breaks

- nails drag / dig / rake
- teeth scrape / graze / catch
- fingers curl / grip / press
- back arches / bows / curves
- legs spread / open / wrap
- hands grip / anchor / brace / guide

Mess and Aftermath (Required)

- come leaking / dripping / pooling
- streaked across skin
- smeared
- sheets ruined / wet / tangled
- sticky
- sore (next day)
- ache (physical, earned)
- tender
- swollen
- marked (when earned and plausible)

4.12 POSITIVE GUIDANCE: DIALOGUE

Erotic dialogue should be:

- Filthy
- Clipped
- Character-specific
- Tied to action or demand

Effective Dialogue Types

- Commands: "Stay open." "Don't move." "Deeper." "Again."
- Demands: "Harder." "More." "Don't stop." "Look at me."
- Reactions: "Fuck." "Right there." "Yes." "Please."
- Observations: "So tight." "You're shaking." "You're close."
- Questions: "Too much?" "You want this?" "Can you take more?"
- Praise: "Good." "Perfect." "That's it."

Dialogue Should NOT Be

- Philosophical
- Analytical

- Explaining the dynamic while in it
- Narrating what's happening
- Theme statements about love/sex/power
- Speeches

4.13 POSITIVE GUIDANCE: CONSENT

Consent Shown in Action

- Obedience to positioning
- Staying open / still / available
- Repositioning self for better access
- Asking for more
- Verbal confirmation without rote formula
- Active participation
- Reaching for partner
- Guiding hands / mouth / body

Consent NOT Shown Through

- Scripted consent speeches
- Legal-contract language
- Interrupting action for formal check-ins (unless character-specific)
- Narration explaining that consent was given

4.14 POSITIVE GUIDANCE: AFTERCARE

Aftercare should be visible and specific:

- Touch (stroking, holding, adjusting position)
- Practical care (water, food, cleaning up)
- Banter or teasing
- Silence that's comfortable rather than tense
- Physical closeness or deliberate space
- Acknowledgment of what just happened through action

Aftercare should NOT be:

- Moralized
- A "lesson learned" moment

- A therapy session about the sex
- Narrated explanation of why aftercare matters

4.15 CONTRAST AND DESCRIPTION

Erotic Contrast (Permitted)

Visual and tactile contrast between bodies is erotic when:

- It serves the scene and action
- It's grounded in what characters perceive
- It doesn't reduce any character to their appearance
- It avoids fetishization language

Contrast Should NOT Be

- The primary focus over action or psychology
- Described using banned racial/ethnic terms
- Decorative without function
- Repetitive (once established, don't keep restating)

4.16 REALISM REQUIREMENTS

Anatomy

- Large penetration requires adjustment, easing in, accommodation
- One-thrust full penetration is not realistic with significant size
- Position affects depth, angle, and what's possible
- Bodies have weight, leverage limitations, and fatigue

Physics

- Standing sex requires support
- Certain grips are impossible to maintain during certain motions
- Height differences create logistics that must be addressed
- Flexibility has limits

Vocalization

- Realistic sounds: moans, gasps, caught breath, rough exhale, low curse, bitten-off sound, voice breaking
- Not realistic: screaming orgasms, constant loud moaning, theatrical vocalization

Fluids

- Realistic amounts, even with high volume
- Mess is specific and located
- Cleanup or acknowledgment exists

4.17 SCENE STRUCTURE REQUIREMENTS

Every Erotic Scene Must

- Change something (trust, power, dynamic, knowledge, relationship)
- Have identifiable POV (maximum two)
- Anchor in specific time, place, and circumstance
- End on action, decision, rupture, or external interruption

Every Erotic Scene Must NOT

- Exist in isolation from story psychology
- End on summary or fade-out
- End on stillness without consequence
- Serve only as "reward" with no narrative function

4.18 ENDING REQUIREMENTS

End On

- Collapse (physical)
- Command (verbal)
- Rupture (emotional shift)
- External event (interruption, intrusion)
- Decision (what happens next)
- Touch (specific, meaningful)
- Breath (when it carries weight)
- Mess (when it crystallizes the scene)

Do NOT End On

- Summary of what just happened
- Fade-to-black
- Stillness without cost
- "And for now, that was enough" or equivalent
- Narrated emotional meaning
- Theme statement about sex/love/connection

4.19 PRE-SCENE CHECKLIST

Before writing any erotic scene:

- [ ] POV anchored (max two)
- [ ] What changes by the end identified
- [ ] Ending action chosen
- [ ] Height/proportion logistics considered
- [ ] Character-specific voice notes reviewed
- [ ] Ban list reviewed

4.20 POST-SCENE CHECKLIST

Before finalizing any erotic scene:

- [ ] Any banned words/phrases present? (Search and remove)
- [ ] Any euphemisms? (Replace with plain terms)
- [ ] Any religious language? (Remove)
- [ ] Any porno tropes? (Remove or ground in realism)
- [ ] Any cartoonish fluids/volumes? (Scale to realistic)
- [ ] Any impossible anatomy/physics? (Fix logistics)
- [ ] Consent visible in action?
- [ ] Aftercare present or acknowledged?
- [ ] Mess and consequence visible?
- [ ] Does the scene end on action/decision/rupture?
- [ ] Did something change?
- [ ] Character voices distinct throughout?

4.21 QUICK-SCAN: EROTICA-SPECIFIC

Search Term	Action
slick / spend / release / essence	Replace with plain terms
Oh God / Jesus / Christ	Delete
guttural	Replace with rough/torn/low
worship / altar / sacred	Delete
forehead sheen / beading sweat	Delete or replace with heat/tremor
slamming / impaling / pistoning	Replace with varied, realistic motion
screamed	Replace with voice broke / cried out / gasped
tongues battling	Rewrite kiss entirely
tracing patterns/circles	Delete or replace with purposeful touch
buried to the hilt	Delete or describe depth specifically
spent / ruined / wrecked / undone	Describe actual physical state
hard enough to bruise	Delete—describe firmness without injury
tasted of salt	Delete
smelled of sex	Delete

APPENDIX: MASTER QUICK-SCAN

Full Search Protocol

Run these searches on completed drafts:

Constructions

- ", then"
- "something" + verb

- "silence" + stretches/hangs/sits
- "not [X], but [Y]"
- "isn't quite"
- "hangs in the air"
- "like a blow/punch/freight train"
- "like a stone"
- triple noun/fragment sequences
- "[Verb]. [Verb]. [Verb]."
- "And" / "But" sentence starts
- "Because [X]." fragments
- "from X to Y" (check if real scale)
- "the older man" / descriptor cycling
- participle + highlighting/underscoring
- "not only... but"

Words and Phrases

- jaw / throat / hand + tension
- breath + hitch/catch/release
- "pupils blown"
- something + shifts/breaks/changes
- raw / carefully / finally
- "weight of"
- "for a moment/beat"
- "the need"
- steel / iron / velvet / silk
- "surgical precision" / "practiced ease"
- Oh God / Jesus / Christ
- guttural
- "And for now, that was enough"
- delve / tapestry / landscape / pivotal / crucial / vibrant
- highlighting / underscoring / showcasing
- nestled / boasts / vibrant

Erotica-Specific

- slick / spend / release / essence / core / length / folds
- worship / altar / sacred
- forehead sheen / beading sweat / glistening
- slamming / impaling / pistoning / pounding
- screamed / shrieked / wailed
- tongues battling
- tracing patterns / lazy circles
- buried to the hilt

- spent / ruined / wrecked / undone / boneless
- hard enough to bruise
- tasted of salt / smelled of sex

The Final Principle

Every banned element shares one root cause: **substituting form for content, decoration for precision, or familiar rhythm for earned meaning.**

The corrective is always the same: **Be specific. Be embodied. Show consequence.**

If a line exists to sound literary, cut it. If a gesture is generic, make it individual. If a metaphor doesn't clarify, delete it. If nothing changes, the scene isn't done.

This document is a personal style guide. Use what applies. Ignore what doesn't. The goal is clarity about your own preferences—not compliance with mine.